

KF Mini-Meeting Lesson 3

--"MINI-MEETNG" FORMAT-- (20 min)

I - MINDFULLNESS (4 min)

-ANB (1 min)

-3 Minute Breathing Space (3 min)

II - CHECK-IN (10 min)

-KF Member "A" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

-KF Member "B" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

III - KF MEETING "PREVIEW" (6 min)

-Bible Teaching -- selected excerpt of upcoming KF Bible teaching (5 min)

-Ending Prayer (1 min)

BIBLE TEACHING

In this lesson, we will begin looking at a famous passage in the letter from James, which you can find toward the end of the New Testament, just after Hebrews. This is Nancy's translation of **James 1:1–4**, with paraphrase for clarity.

¹James, a bond-servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, to the twelve tribes who are dispersed abroad—greetings. ²Guide yourselves into all joy, my siblings, when you fall into and are surrounded by all kinds of experiments, ³knowing that the examination of what you truly trust and act upon results in the ability to remain under examination as it explores your ever-expanding potential. ⁴Give this growing ability to endure a chance to accomplish its purpose, which is to make you a mature and complete being, lacking nothing, fully equipped for your joy and mission.

Take a deep breath.

James, or Jacob in Hebrew, is writing to the Jewish Christians who were forced by persecution to scatter throughout the Roman Empire. These people knew suffering and fear, and yet James tells them this: "Guide yourselves into all joy when you fall into all kinds of experiments."

When interpreting this passage, some translators use the words *consider it all joy*, but the word *consider* can also mean to *lead or guide oneself*. You can guide ourselves into all joy when you fall into various tests. These various tests, or experiments, are your days of judgment; they are showing you what you are made of. What's more, this passage teaches that you have an active choice in your experiments. You can choose to be joyful and bold as you discover what is real about yourself and about your world.

Look at your KF Confessions again. I hope that you will post them somewhere so that you can keep them in mind. Notice that, through the Confessions, you are regularly committing yourself to an authentic, real, true, and honest life. If you are in Karis Fellowships, you are working toward knowing the truth about yourself, doing true things, and speaking the truth. You will also be learning to step out of the misorientation that hinders you and harms your life. Exploring your misorientation may feel like a

depressing task, but take heart! You won't just be knowing, you will also be growing. Guide yourself into that joy.

Now, what are these experiments that James is talking about? The Greek word, often translated as *trial*, has to do with tests or experiments that reveal what is real, what is there. When we are interested in the True Self, which Karen Horney calls the real self, we are interested in what is real about ourselves right now. We are like researchers who are not judging an outcome as good or bad, but are eagerly seeking what is real and true. We also want to know what is possible. When we approach a scientific experiment without preconceived ideas about the outcome, we are excited about what we are going to discover. The same principle applies when we examine our lives.

Conversely, if we approach an experiment with preconceived ideas about what we want to see, what would be good or bad, and what would support our pride, we come to the experiment with apprehension. We are fixated on an outcome that our pride feels it must have. We are predicting the future, and that takes us out of the real present. We are not joyful or creative about the process. Rather, we are anxious, and our observation is distorted by our efforts to save the Idol's life. We may even avoid acknowledging what we see, even if it is beneficial, because it doesn't fit our preconceived illusions.

The True Self, on the other hand, is motivated by love and is eager for truth to be revealed in our lives. Love, after all, rejoices in the truth. Here is an interesting observation about the word *experience*. The spelling of the words *experience* and *experiment* is almost the same. That's because they used to be the same word in our language. All of your experiences are experiments with reality and can be interpreted as opportunities, or days of judgment, that show you the truth of who you are right now; they reveal your actual self. Experiences measure your progress as you develop the potential of your real glory. Free from the judgments that support your pride, you can rejoice in what you learn. You can rejoice because these discoveries are essential for your growth. *In order to get where you want to go, you have to know where you are right now. (Repeat)*

Our prayer might go something like this:

Loving Father, teach me to rejoice in my experiments. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,
Thank you for this time together of healing and training. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our glory and to the truth about our faith. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.